

Peer Review: IT Project Refinement and Ethical Integration

Reviewer: Josue Neiculeo

Classmate reviewed: Jesse Moroni Milton

Project: Heritage Vault 2.0

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What stood out to me technically

After reading Jesse's Heritage Vault 2.0 proposal, I thought the refinements made a lot of sense because they were connected to actual problems instead of just adding features for the sake of adding them. The public, family-only, and private visibility levels were one of the things that stood out to me most. I like that approach because family history information is not always something that should be either completely public or completely hidden. Having different levels of access gives the user more control over what other people can see.

I also liked that the security monitoring and audit logging were connected to the MyHeritage breach Jesse discussed earlier. That made the security improvement feel more real to me. It showed that the feature came from thinking about something that could actually happen, rather than simply saying that the system needed to be more secure. The accessibility improvements and the vault successor idea also show that Jesse was thinking about the project beyond the immediate user experience and considering what happens to information over time.

The main question I had was about how some of these ideas would work once the system is actually built. Right now, the project is still presented as a proposal, so some parts are hard to judge from a technical point of view. For example, I understand the family-only setting, but I was left wondering how the system would enforce it at the database level and how it would stop information from being exposed indirectly through another family relationship. I also think scalability needs a little more detail. Jesse clearly identifies the problem of having thousands of connected family records, but I wanted to see a little more about what would change in the actual data structure or storage approach to handle that problem.

The ethical side felt especially strong

The ethical part was probably the section I connected with the most. The question about storing information about living relatives is easy to overlook in a family history system because the person entering the information may not be the same person the information is about. Jesse's example made that problem much easier to see. A living person may have information stored about them without ever making that choice themselves, so the consent issue is much more than a general statement about privacy.

I also thought the vault successor idea was interesting because it looks at what happens to ownership and responsibility after the original user dies. That is a question I had not really considered before reading the project. Instead of only pointing out the problem, Jesse tried to build a feature around it, which made the ethical thinking feel connected to the actual design.

There is one question I think Jesse could explore a little more. If the person whose information is being stored is alive but is not the person using the system, who is actually allowed to give consent? The proposal includes a consent flag for sharing information beyond the immediate family, which is a good start, but the person controlling the account may not be the same person

whose information is being shared. I think even a short explanation of that situation would make the ethical part stronger.

A couple of things I would suggest

For the technical side, I would add a short explanation of how the scalability problem would actually be handled. It does not need to become a full engineering design, but even naming the approach and explaining why it would help would make the refinement feel more complete. For example, Jesse could explain whether the system would change the way family relationships are stored or indexed so that large family trees can be searched without slowing the system down.

For the ethical side, I would explain who has the authority to give consent when the person being documented is not the person managing the vault. There may not be one perfect answer, and I think it would be okay to say that this is still an open question. What matters is showing that the system recognizes the problem and does not assume that one family member automatically has the right to make that decision for someone else.

I also think Jesse could show one small example of what would happen in a real situation. For example, it could explain what the system would do when someone tries to share a living relative's record and there is no consent on file. A simple example like that would help connect the idea to everyday use and make the design easier for someone like me to picture.

What I learned from reviewing it

One thing I want to take from Jesse's project is the way he connects a real-world problem to a specific design decision. The MyHeritage example is not just mentioned as an interesting case. It actually helps explain why security monitoring and audit logging belong in the project. I usually think about ethical issues as something I should check after I have the main technical idea, but this review reminded me that the ethical problem can actually help shape the design from the beginning.

That connects with what I am trying to do in my own IT work. When I build AI or data tools, I want to get better at asking what could go wrong, who could be affected, and what I can change in the design before the problem happens. Jesse's project gave me a good example of what that can look like in practice.

Overall thoughts

Overall, I think Heritage Vault 2.0 is a strong improvement from the original idea. What I liked most is that the technical and ethical sides are connected instead of being treated as two separate sections. The project identifies real concerns around scalability, accessibility, privacy for living people, and what happens to information after the original owner is gone, and it responds to those concerns with actual features. My main suggestions are to make the scalability solution more concrete and to explain the consent question for living people in more detail.

I think those changes would make an already thoughtful project easier to understand and also easier to turn into a real system later. More importantly, the project made me think about how technical decisions can affect people in ways that are not always obvious when you first start building something.